

NICO Capital

for Iraq

A Sovereign Partnership for Iraq's Financial Future

Building digital financial infrastructure for Iraq's 46 million citizens

46M

Pop. Median Age 21

26M+

Adults Unbanked

84%

Internet 2025

\$515B

GDP

Thomas K. Matecki | CEO & Founder | NICO Capital Ltd | Co. No. 16839544 | London

Prepared for: Central Bank of Iraq | Ministry of Finance | Kurdistan Regional Government

PART I -- EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Case for NICO in Iraq

Iraq in 2026 is the most significant financial inclusion opportunity in the Middle East. A nation of 46 million people, median age 21, 84% internet penetration, a government-mandated digital payments programme, and a CBI actively recruiting credible international fintech partners. Yet 26M+ adults remain formally unbanked. Credit is 9% of GDP vs 64% in UAE and 100% in Qatar. An estimated \$6B+ in annual diaspora remittances flow through informal hawala networks that formal institutions cannot capture. This is not a risk. This is the opportunity.

National Financial Inclusion Strategy 2025-2029 (World Bank, IMF, UNDP, USAID): targets 50% account ownership and 85% digital payment adoption by 2030. CBI digital banking regulations issued. 70+ entities applied. Monthly digital payments tripled from 2.6T IQD (Jan 2023) to 7.6T IQD (2025). The window is open.

NICO Capital proposes a phased sovereign partnership beginning with the UK-Iraq remittance corridor (450,000+ Iraqi diaspora in UK) and scaling to full digital banking integration. Founded by Thomas K. Matecki, former CTO of Zilch (\$2B+ BNPL unicorn, 100K to 3M+ customers in 18 months). Nexa9, NICO's proprietary tech house, builds every product in-house -- no outsourcing, no dependencies.

PART II -- IRAQ FINANCIAL METRICS 2025-2026

The Market at a Glance

Total Commercial Banks	72
State Bank Asset Share	80-85% of total
Adults with Bank Accounts (2025)	~40% (from 10% in 2018)
Adults Still Unbanked	26M+
Mobile Connections	50.8M (108% of population)
Internet Penetration	83.8%
Monthly E-Payment Volume	7.6 Trillion IQD
Credit-to-GDP Ratio	9% (UAE 64% / Qatar 100%)
NFIS Account Target 2030	50%
NFIS Digital Payment Target	85%
Sector NPL Ratio	14.7%
Annual Formal Remittances	\$1.2B (informal ~\$5-6B)
Digital Bank Licence Applicants	70+ (CBI, 2024-25)
Gov. E-Payment Mandate	June 2025 -- all ministries

PART III -- GLOBAL NEOBANK PROOF POINTS

Every Emerging Market Has Had Its Neobank Moment. Iraq's Is Now.

These companies entered markets structurally identical to Iraq in 2026: large unbanked populations, entrenched legacy banks, nascent digital infrastructure, and government mandate. Each became a category-defining institution worth billions. The pattern is documented. Iraq is the next chapter.

Company	Market/Yr	Valuation	Customers	Entry Context	Iraq Parallel
Nubank	Brazil 2013	\$30B NYSE	100M+	60M unbanked; 5-bank oligopoly	26M+ unbanked; state bank
M-Pesa	Kenya 2007	\$1B+ Safaric.	51M+	Cash-only economy	57% cash monetary base
Paytm	India 2010	\$16B peak	350M+	80% unbanked; gov demonet.	Gov e-pay mandate June 20
GCash	Philippines	\$5B	94M+	OFW diaspora remittance gap	Iraqi diaspora UK/EU corr
TymeBank	S Africa 2018	\$1.5B	9M+	Post-conflict trust deficit	Post-war trust deficit
NICO Iraq	Iraq 2026	\$1B+ 7yr	2-5M 5yr	26M unbanked; NFIS; CBI reform	THE CONVERGENCE MOMENT

PART IV -- PHASED DEPLOYMENT ROADMAP

From MOU to Market Leader

PHASE 0 | Months 1-3

Foundation: Sign the MOU

MOU with CBI and/or Ministry of Finance. Iraqi legal entity. In-country counsel retained. Stakeholder mapping: CBI, PMO, KRG Finance. Nexa9 technical scoping. Licensing strategy submitted.

PHASE 1 | Months 3-15

Pilot: UK-Iraq Remittance Corridor Live

CBI E-Payment Services Licence (10B IQD capital). FCA registration. NICO app live (iOS + Android, EN + AR). 50,000 users; \$25M+ transactions. Monthly CBI reporting.

PHASE 2 | Months 15-36

Expansion: Consumer Platform & SME Onboarding

Full IQD digital wallet. Kurdistan Region priority (Erbil/Sulaymaniyah). 10,000 SME merchants. 500,000 users. Islamic finance products. EU-Iraq corridors.

PHASE 3 | Months 36-72

Digital Bank: Full Licence & National Footprint

CBI 2024 digital banking licence. Full accounts, Visa/Mastercard, micro-lending. 2M+ users across 18 governorates. Women's inclusion programme. CBDC Digital Dinar partnership.

PART V -- LEADERSHIP

Thomas K. Matecki

CEO & Founder | NICO Capital Ltd | Co. No. 16839544 | London

Former Chief Technology Officer of Zilch -- Europe's \$2B+ BNPL unicorn. Led all technology infrastructure during hyper-growth: 100,000 to 3M+ customers in 18 months. Built real-time credit decisioning, payment processing, and compliance architecture from the ground up. Not advisory -- end to end, under pressure, at speed.

Founded NICO Capital with a mission to build financial infrastructure for chronically underbanked populations. Active GBP 10M seed round. Deployments in Caribbean, Dominican Republic, and Philippines (signed LOI with Rakuten Viber; Al-Amanah Islamic Investment Bank). Nexa9 builds every product in-house.

Zilch Achievement	100,000 to 3M+ customers in 18 months
Zilch Valuation	\$2B+
NICO Seed Round	GBP 10M (active)
Technology Delivery	Full-stack in-house via Nexa9 -- zero outsourcing
Emerging Market Track	Caribbean, Dominican Republic, Philippines
Iraq Positioning	First international operator seeking CBI sovereign partnership

"Iraq in 2026 stands at exactly the inflection point that Brazil occupied in 2013, when Nubank launched with a credit card and a conviction. The demographics, the regulatory momentum, the digital infrastructure -- it all converges here. I built it at Zilch. Iraq is the moment." -- Thomas K. Matecki, CEO, NICO Capital Ltd

PART VI -- THE THREE-STEP PARTNERSHIP ASK

Three Steps. One Transformative Partnership.**STEP 1 | Months 1-3****Sign the MOU**

Formal MOU with CBI and/or Ministry of Finance. Defines roles, regulatory cooperation, reporting obligations, and e-payment licence pathway. No financial commitment. A sovereign signal.

STEP 2 | Months 3-15**Mandate the Pilot**

CBI E-Payment Licence under Regulation No. 2 (2024). UK-Iraq corridor launched. Government co-designs pilot framework. NICO commits to monthly data sharing and full CBI audit access.

STEP 3 | Months 24-36**Co-Invest in Scale**

Iraqi sovereign or development vehicle co-invests in NICO Series A. Equity partnership in a company that has already demonstrated delivery in Iraq. Terms subject to pilot outcomes and mutual agreement.

The Window is Open. The Question is Who Walks Through It.

Iraq's NFIS 2025-2029 created the mandate. The CBI created the regulatory pathway. UNDP and USAID committed. A 46M population with median age 21 is the demographic tailwind. NICO Capital is ready. We ask for the opportunity to prove it.